Mahal may have come about even without the death of one of his several wives.

Which argument has more weight? In truth, the evidence from records of the period is mixed. The Shah's court was Persian in character, and Persian writings of the day (like the writings of the Romantic 18th century English) were known to be florid in their descriptions and overflowing with tales of sorrow and emotion. In other words, the story of Jahan's love seems to fit within that genre, making it possible that the Persian scribes added a sense of grandeur that may not have actually existed. Moreover, most accounts of the day, including official British diplomatic reports, describe Jahan as arrogant and supremely self-centered. They also reported his continued attentions to both his wives and to other lovers, including reports of incestuous affairs with Princess Jahanara being brought to the attention of Muslim authorities. While these reports are broadly ignored in the tale of the Taj, they bring an extra layer of complexity to the actual history[4].

The Taj Mahal as a monument might also offer some clues. The construction of a grand mausoleum for a wife had no precedent in any of the architectural traditions that the Mughals blended (including Muslim, Persian, Hindu and Mongol influences), and such a project was not repeated afterwards. Moreover, there is no similar commemoration of a wife in any other culture of the world; the only mausoleums of similar grandeur are all dedicated to male rulers (such as the Great Pyramid of Giza dedicated to Khufu or the Kumsusan Palace of the Sun in North Korea that houses Kim Il-Sung and Kim Jong-Il). It seems to evoke the mournful love like similar elegies for deceased wives like Niel Gow's "Lament for the Death of his Second Wife."

Even if Shah Jahan would have constructed some sort of monument in the first years of his reign without the death of a wife, the fact that he may have chosen to commemorate his companion in such a way is revealing not of the character of the man so much as the strength of his feeling. If the widely believed story about the origins of the Taj Mahal is true, perhaps the greatest lesson it teaches viewers is that one didn’t need to be a saint to love deeply or completely pure of heart to mourn completely.

Chapter 2: The Mughal Empire